

India-Nordic Summit 2026



For Prelims: Nordic region , India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement , LeadIT2.0 , Nordic-Baltic Eight (NB8) , Arctic Council

For Mains: India's relations with the Nordic countries and the strategic importance, Nordic Council and Nordic-Baltic cooperation

Source:TH

Why in News?

The Prime Minister of India concluded a highly significant diplomatic tour of the **Nordic region** , visiting **Oslo, Norway** , to participate in the **3 rd India-Nordic Summit** .

- Hosted by Norway, the summit brought together the Prime Minister of India and the leaders of the five **Nordic nations** (Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, and Sweden) to review bilateral ties and address contemporary global challenges.

Summary

- The 3rd India-Nordic Summit strengthened cooperation in green technology, innovation, trade, maritime security, AI, space, and climate action, while also deepening strategic ties through agreements such as India-EFTA TEPA and the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative.
- Despite strong potential, India-Nordic relations face challenges such as geopolitical differences over Russia, strict ESG standards, low trade volume, regulatory barriers, and technology-related concerns, requiring stronger investment, connectivity, and policy coordination.

What are the Key Highlights of the 3 rd India-Nordic Summit?

- Strategic Partnership Upgrade:** The summit officially elevated the relationship between **India and the Nordic nations** (Denmark, Norway, Finland, Iceland, and Sweden) to a **trusted Green**

Technology and Innovation Strategic Partnership.

- The collaboration is heavily anchored in shared democratic values, a rules-based global order, and a mutual focus on sustainable development and tech innovation.
- **Trade & Economic Integration:** The leaders highlighted the implementation of the [India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement \(TEPA\)](#) and the conclusion of the **India-EU Free Trade Agreement**.
 - A major shared objective under TEPA is driving **USD 100 billion in investments** into India, projected to create one million direct jobs.
- **Climate Action & The Blue Economy:** Iceland was welcomed as a new member of [LeadIT2.0](#) , a public-private platform focused on decarbonizing heavy industries.
 - This includes transitioning the shipping industry to low-carbon models and adhering to the [Hong Kong Convention for environmentally safe ship recycling](#).
- **Technology, Space & Defense:** The summit emphasized democratizing AI, securing 5G/6G infrastructure, and building global AI governance frameworks (building on **India's successful hosting of the AI Impact Summit in 2026**).
 - Announced a new Framework Agreement between [ISRO and the Norwegian Space Agency](#), as well as a confirmed **Swedish payload for India's upcoming Venus Orbiter Mission (Shukrayaan 1)**.
 - India highlighted that Nordic defense firms can now take advantage of **100% Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)** in Indian Defense Industrial Corridors.
- **Global Geopolitics & Security:**
 - **UN Reform:** The Nordic countries explicitly reiterated their support for India **gaining a permanent seat on a reformed UN Security Council** and backing its application to the [Nuclear Suppliers' Group \(NSG\)](#).
 - **Counter-Terrorism:** Strongly condemned cross-border terrorism specifically referencing the **2025 attacks in Pahalgam** and [New Delhi](#) and committed to disrupting global terror financing channels.

Previous Summits

- **1st India-Nordic Summit:** Stockholm, Sweden (2018)
- **2nd India-Nordic Summit:** Copenhagen, Denmark (2022)
- **Next Destination:** The leaders decided that the **4th India-Nordic Summit** will be hosted by **Finland** .

What are the Key Outcomes of India's Bilateral Engagements With Norway?

- **Conferment of Top State Honour:** PM Narendra Modi was awarded the **Grand Cross of the Royal Norwegian Order of Merit** by King Harald V, which is Norway's **highest civilian honour** bestowed on foreign heads of government.
- **Maritime Security Dialogue:** India and Norway officially instituted a dedicated **Maritime Security Dialogue** .

- This framework aims to enhance information sharing, inter-agency coordination, and tackle **Illicit Maritime Activities (IMA)** such as piracy, smuggling, and illegal fishing.
- **Sovereign Investment Corridor:** The leaders actively discussed creating a "**Sovereign Investment Corridor.**"
 - It is designed to directly channel patient capital from **Norway's massive sovereign wealth fund** (one of the world's largest) into India's long-term green infrastructure and renewable energy projects.
 - It bypasses traditional, slower **foreign portfolio investment** routes by offering a state-backed guarantee of ease of doing business.
- **Expansion of the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI):** In a major strategic move, Norway formally joined **India's IPOI**.
 - This signals a growing European alignment with India's vision for a free, open, and prosperous Indo-Pacific region, expanding ties beyond the economic realm into maritime security.

Other Key Bilateral Engagements

- **Finland:** India and Finland elevated bilateral ties to a **Strategic Partnership in Digitalization and Sustainability** .
 - Both sides agreed to deepen cooperation in AI, 5G/6G, quantum technologies, renewable energy, innovation, and circular economy, while reaffirming their commitment to **doubling bilateral trade by 2030** and **jointly hosting the World Circular Economy Forum in Gujarat in September 2026**.
- **Denmark:** India and Denmark reviewed progress under the **India-Denmark Green Strategic Partnership launched in 2020**.
 - Both sides agreed to strengthen cooperation in climate action, green transition, AI, defence, advanced research, and start-ups.

Nordic Region

- **Geographical Composition:** The region consists of **Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, and Sweden** , alongside three autonomous territories: the **Faroe Islands and Greenland** (associated with Denmark) and the **Åland Islands** (associated with Finland).
- **Nordic vs. Scandinavia:** Though frequently used interchangeably, **Scandinavia is a more restrictive geographic term referring primarily to Denmark, Norway, and Sweden** , whereas "Nordic" encompasses the broader five-nation group and its territories.
- **Regional Demographics:** Within this bloc, **Sweden stands as the largest and most populous country** , while **Denmark is the smallest** in landmass and **Iceland is the least populous** .
- **Socio-Economic Benchmarks:** The region is globally renowned for the "**Nordic Model**," consistently ranking at the top of international indices for **education, civil liberties, quality of life, and economic competitiveness** .
- **Diverse Political Structures:** The region splits its governance styles; **Denmark, Sweden, and**

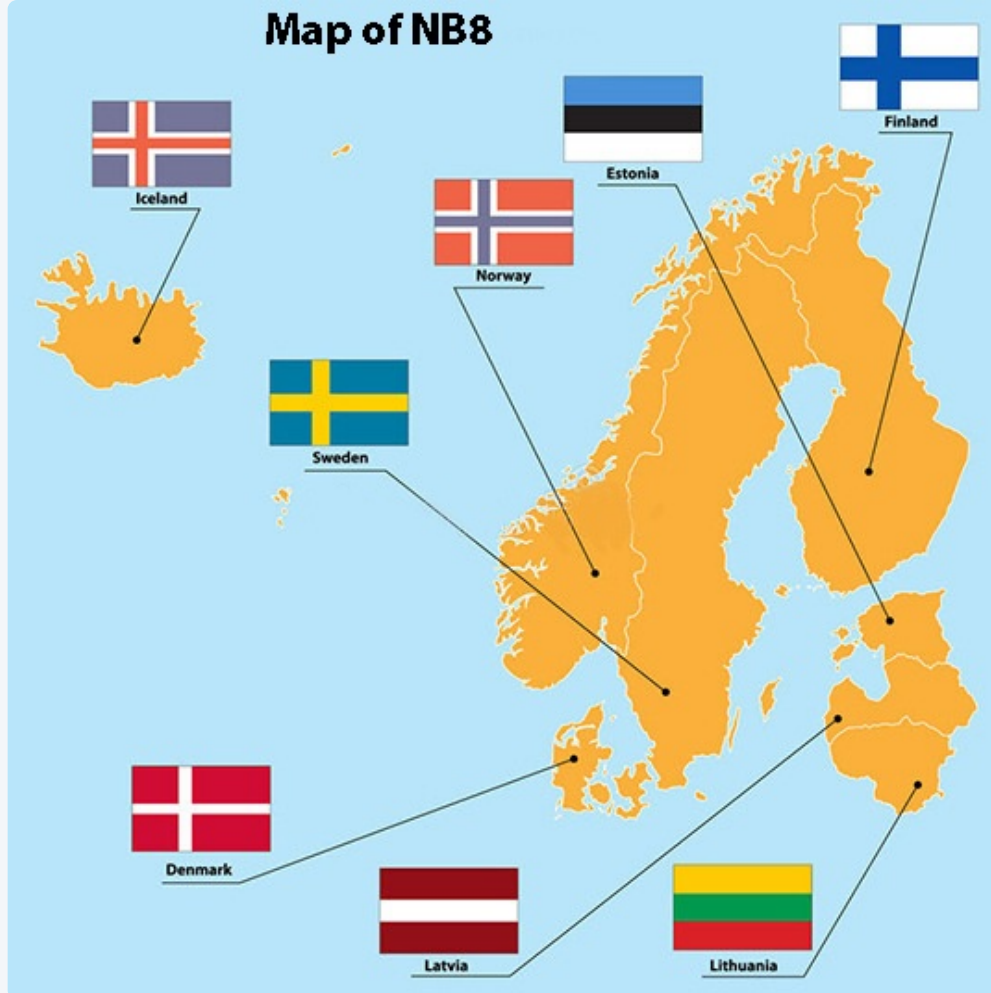
Norway are constitutional monarchies and parliamentary democracies , while **Finland and Iceland function as democratic republics** .

- **Institutional Governance:** Inter-governmental and parliamentary cooperation is formally maintained through the **Nordic Council** and the **Nordic Council of Ministers** .
 - The Nordic Council is the official body for cooperation among Nordic countries, established in 1952. It promotes regional cooperation, improves the lives of Nordic citizens, and addresses shared challenges such as climate change, sustainability, security, and digital transformation.
 - **Finland holds the Presidency of the Nordic Council for 2026. Its Secretariat is located in Copenhagen.**
 - **India is the only country besides** the US to have summit-level ties with the Nordics collectively.
- **Overlapping European Alignments:** The countries differ in their integration with continental bodies:
 - **Denmark, Sweden, and Finland are members of the European Union (EU)** .
 - Norway and Iceland are not EU members but participate via the European Economic Area (EEA) and the **European Free Trade Association (EFTA)**.

Nordic-Baltic Eight

- **Nordic-Baltic Eight (NB8)** is an informal coalition that unites five Nordic and three Baltic nations (**Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania**) to foster strategic regional collaboration.
- Within the group, the six EU member states (excluding Iceland and Norway) convene under the **NB6 format to coordinate EU-specific policies** .
- Currently chaired by **Estonia for 2026**, the NB8 is increasingly prioritizing its strategic partnership with India.
 - This alignment was highlighted during the **2023 CII India Nordic-Baltic Business Conclave**, which focused on deepening bilateral cooperation across innovation, green technology, maritime affairs, and space exploration.

Map of NB8



What is the Significance of the Nordic Region for India?

- The "Innovation-Scale" Synergy:** The Nordic countries consistently rank at the top of global innovation, digitalization, and sustainability indices.
 - Sweden, Finland and Denmark are among the world's top ten most innovative economies according to the **World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO)**.
 - They possess capital, IP, and advanced R&D. India offers a massive data **pool, demographic scale, and a booming market**, creating a perfect complementary synergy.
- Arctic-Indo-Pacific Interlinkage:** As the Arctic ice melts, opening new sea routes and access to critical minerals, the geopolitical theatre is expanding.
 - India, an Observer in the **Arctic Council**, views the Nordic nations as crucial partners for **polar research (e.g., India's Himadri station in Svalbard, Norway)**, climate monitoring, and securing its strategic interests in the High North.
- Defense Industrial Base Expansion:** The **100% FDI** is now available for Nordic defense firms within the **Indian Defence Industrial Corridors** (e.g., UP and Tamil Nadu nodes).
 - This aligns with India's **Atmanirbhar Bharat push** in defense manufacturing.
- Pioneering the Circular Economy:** The Nordic model of circular economy, bioeconomy, and plastic pollution management (aligning with UNEA Resolution 5/14) provides a scalable template for India's **Mission LiFE** (Lifestyle for Environment).
- Global Supply Chain Resilience:** The partnership is critical for integrating the NB8 region into the

What are the Challenges in India-Nordic Relations?

- **Geopolitical Divergence:** Nordic countries, particularly Finland and Sweden, perceive Russia as a major security threat and have joined **NATO** , whereas India continues to maintain strategic and defense ties with Russia under its policy of strategic autonomy. This can create diplomatic differences.
- **Trade Imbalance and Low Volume:** Despite robust relations, the actual bilateral trade volume (historically hovering around USD 13 billion) is well below its potential when compared to India's trade with other European giants like France or Germany.
- **ESG and Human Rights Standards:** Nordic countries strongly emphasize **environmental sustainability, labor rights, human rights, press freedom, transparency,** and governance standards in trade and investment agreements.
 - India often views these conditions as restrictive non-tariff barriers that may affect its domestic economic priorities and create trust-related concerns in economic cooperation.
- **Regulatory and Investment Barriers:** Complex regulations, land acquisition challenges, concerns over taxation, and slow contract enforcement in India discourage risk-averse **Nordic investors and sovereign wealth funds** from making large-scale investments.
- **Intellectual Property and Technology Concerns:** Nordic economies depend heavily on innovation and advanced technology.
 - Concerns regarding **India's Intellectual Property Rights (IPR) regime** and **technology-sharing policies** can slow cooperation in sectors such as green hydrogen, renewable energy, and 6G technology.
- **Low Trade and Connectivity:** Despite growing political engagement, **trade between India and the Nordic region remains limited.**
 - Weak maritime connectivity and supply-chain linkages increase freight costs and reduce business integration.
- **Market Scale and Cost Differences:** Nordic countries have small but high-income markets, while India is a large price-sensitive market.
 - As a result, expensive Nordic green technologies often require localization and cost reduction before they can be widely adopted in India.

What Measures can Strengthen India-Nordic Relations?

- **Single-Window Fast-Track Mechanism:** To effectively absorb the targeted USD 100 billion investment under the India-EFTA -TEPA, India must establish a dedicated **"Nordic-Baltic Desk" within Invest India** .
 - This desk should offer fast-tracked regulatory clearances, streamlined land acquisition, and clear tax dispute resolution mechanisms.
- **Diversifying Trade:** There is an urgent need to expand bilateral trade beyond traditional goods by heavily integrating high-value tech, healthcare, and green manufacturing sectors.
- **Blue Economy Taskforce:** Establish a dedicated joint task force to commercialize zero-emission

shipping technologies, green hydrogen bunkering, and advanced marine biotechnology.

- **Frugal Engineering for Green Tech:** By leveraging India's vast market scale and **frugal manufacturing capabilities**, Nordic nations technologies can be cost-engineered, localized, and jointly exported to the Global South.
 - India should introduce specialized **Joint IP Protection Protocols** for deep-tech sectors like 6G, quantum computing, and space engineering.
- **Sustained Multilateral Cooperation:** India and the Nordic bloc must continue to act as a bridge between the Global North and Global South, particularly in mobilizing affordable climate finance and pushing for equitable AI governance.

Conclusion

The India-Nordic partnership can be built on the foundation of **green collaboration and technological co-development** rather than just traditional military pacts. The capital and innovation of the High North with the democratic scale of India will not only ensure **mutual economic security but will also provide a scalable model for global sustainable development**.

Drishti Mains Question:

"India-Nordic ties are driven by cooperation, but constrained by strategic and regulatory differences." Analyse.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Nordic Council?

The Nordic Council is the official inter-parliamentary body for Nordic cooperation, established in 1952 to promote regional cooperation and address shared challenges such as sustainability, security, and digital transformation.

2. Why are the Nordic countries important for India?

They offer a strong combination of capital, innovation, R&D, and sustainability expertise, while India provides scale, markets, and demographic strength, creating a natural complementarity.

3. What are the main challenges in India-Nordic relations?

The major challenges include geopolitical divergence on Russia, low trade volume, strict ESG and human rights standards, regulatory barriers, IPR concerns, and weak connectivity.

4. What are the key areas of cooperation in the India-Nordic partnership?

Important areas include green technology, trade, space, defense, AI governance, maritime security, and climate action.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/Wn7WDuv0Jjg](https://www.youtube.com/embed/Wn7WDuv0Jjg)]

Prelims

Q. Consider the following countries:

1. Finland
2. Germany
3. Norway
4. Russia

How many of the above countries have a border with the North Sea? (2024)

1. Only one
2. Only two
3. Only three
4. All four

Ans: B

Genomic Mapping of Pangolin Trafficking



Source: TH

A study published in ***PLoS Biology*** has developed a **DNA -based “genetic map”** that can accurately trace the origin and trafficking routes of **illegally traded pangolins** , strengthening efforts to combat global wildlife crime.

- **Identification of Global Poaching Hotspots:** The genomic map pinpointed three primary transnational extraction zones:
 - **Southwestern Cameroon** (white-bellied), **Southwestern Borneo** (Sunda), and **the border region surrounding Myanmar** (Chinese pangolin).
- **Northeast India-China Illicit Axis:** The genomic data revealed an active illicit wildlife network originating from **northeastern India (around Arunachal Pradesh and Assam)** and potentially Bhutan, directly supplying **Yunnan province in China** .
 - The study disproved the assumption that **local and international pangolin trafficking operate separately**, showing that domestic supply hubs overlap with global trafficking networks **linked to China and Vietnam**.

Pangolins

- **Ecological and Behavioral Traits:** Pangolin are **shy, solitary, and mostly nocturnal** mammals that feed exclusively on ants and termites (myrmecophagy).
 - They play an important ecological role by **aerating and enriching the soil through digging**.
 - Due to their **secretive behaviour and slow reproduction rate**, with females usually giving birth to a single young, their populations recover very slowly after decline.
- **Habitat:** It is adaptable to a wide range of habitats including primary and secondary **tropical forests**, limestone and bamboo forests , **grasslands** and agricultural fields.
- **Taxonomical Diversity:** There are eight distinct species globally, evenly split between Africa (Black-bellied, White-bellied, Giant Ground, and Temminck's Ground) and Asia (**Indian, Philippine, Sunda, and Chinese pangolins**).
- **Anatomical Defense Mechanism:** They possess unique, overlapping **scales made of keratin** covering their bodies and exhibit **volvation** (rolling into a tight ball) as an evolutionary defense mechanism against predators.
- **Edentate (Toothless) Anatomy:** Pangolins have zero teeth. Instead, they catch prey using an **extremely long, muscular, and sticky tongue** that is uniquely anchored near their pelvis and the last pair of ribs rather than the jaw.
- **Geographical Distribution in India:** While the **Indian Pangolin (*Manis crassicaudata*) is found across the broader Indian subcontinent** .
 - In India, the Chinese Pangolin (*Manis pentadactyla*) is mainly restricted to the Northeast and is extremely rare.
- **Conservation Classifications:** All eight species of pangolins are strictly regulated under **Appendix I of CITES** .
 - On the **IUCN Red List** , the **Indian Pangolin is classified as Endangered (EN)** , while the **Chinese Pangolin is categorized as Critically Endangered (CR)** .
 - Within India, both the Indian and Chinese pangolins are afforded the highest level of legal immunity under **Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972** .
 - World Pangolin Day is observed on the third Saturday of February.



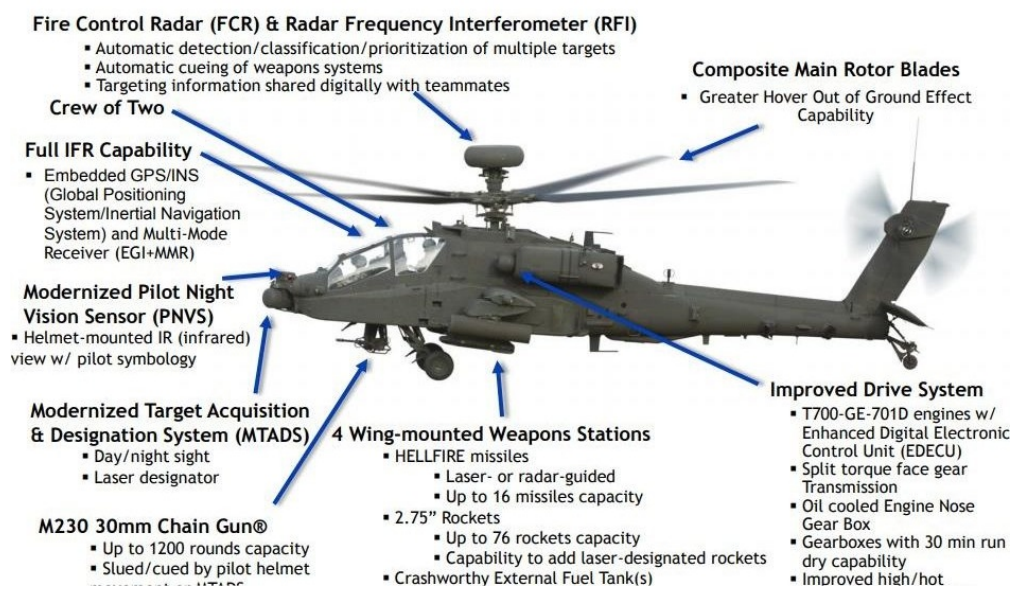
US Clears Apache & Howitzer Support for India



Source: IE

Recently, the United States approved sustainment support and related equipment for **AH-64E Apache helicopters and M777A2 Ultra-Light Howitzers** for India, further boosting bilateral defence ties.

- **Apache Helicopters:** The AH-64 Apache is an **advanced multi-role combat helicopter** used by the US Army and several international defence forces.
 - The **Apache support package**, worth approximately **\$198.2 million**, includes engineering, technical and logistics support, technical data, publications, personnel training and programme support.
- **M777A2 Howitzer:** M777A2 howitzers, recognised for their **lightweight structure and high mobility** in difficult mountainous terrain, are widely deployed by the Indian Army, especially across strategically important border areas.
 - The **M777A2 howitzer support package**, worth about **\$230 million**, includes spares, repair and return, training, technical assistance, field service representatives, depot capability and other logistics support.
- **Other Defence Procurements:** Major acquisitions from the US include **MQ-9B drones, MH-60R helicopters, Sig Sauer rifles and M777 howitzers**. Negotiations are also underway for manufacturing **GE F-414 jet engines** in India, while deliveries of **GE-F404** engines for the **LCA Tejas Mark-1A** are underway.
- **Key India-US Defence Agreements:**
 - **LEMOA (2016)**
 - **COMCASA (2018)**
 - **BECA (2020)**
 - **SOSA (2024)**
 - **Framework for US-India Major Defence Partnership 2025**



Read more: [Indian Army's AH-64E Apache Helicopter Induction](#)